Cajun Dungeness Crab Boil

Cooked Dungeness crabs warm at the end of a Tony's boil with potatoes, corn, and mixed vegetables. Rice-maker rice with chicken Better Than Bouillon sits under the crab. A ladle of the boil is finished with butter and cream. Serves 3, with leftover vegetables.

Ingredients

Dungeness crabs, cooked frozen, whole 3
Water . . . . . 8 qt.
Yellow onions, halved 2–3
Garlic heads, halved crosswise 2
Lemons, halved 2
Bay leaves, divided 3
Tony Chachere's Creole seasoning . . . . . 1/4 cup
Vegetable Better Than Bouillon . . . . . 1 Tbsp.
Long grain white rice . . . . . 1 1/2 cups
Hot water . . . . . 1 1/2 cups
Chicken Better Than Bouillon . . . . . 1 1/2 tsp.
Dehydrated soup vegetables . . . . . 1 Tbsp.
Small white potatoes . . . . . 3 lb.
Carrots, thick chunks . . . . . 1 lb.
Corn on the cob, halved . . . . . 4 ears
Red bell pepper, large pieces 1
Zucchini, thick coins 2
Salted butter, divided . . . . . 8 1/2 Tbsp.
Heavy cream . . . . . 1/4 cup
Slap Ya Mama seasoning . . . . . to taste

Directions

Thaw **crabs** overnight in the refrigerator — Halve **onions** — Halve **garlic heads** crosswise — Halve **lemons** — Scrub **potatoes**; halve any larger than a golf ball — Cut **carrots** into thick chunks — Halve **corn** — Cut **bell pepper** into large pieces — Cut **zucchini** into thick coins — Rinse and split each **crab** in half through the body — Rinse 1 1/2 cups **rice** until the water runs clear

1. Fill a 20–24 qt. pot (or canner) with 8 qt. **water**. Add **onions**, **garlic heads**, **lemons** (squeezed, then dropped in), 2 **bay leaves**, and 1/4 cup **Tony Chachere's**. Cover and bring to a rolling boil over high heat, *15–25 minutes*.

2. While the pot heats, start the rice maker: 1 1/2 cups **rice**, 1 1/2 cups **hot water**, 1 1/2 tsp. **chicken Better Than Bouillon**, 1 **bay leaf**, and 1 Tbsp. **dehydrated soup vegetables**.

3. When the water boils hard, taste it. Add **Tony Chachere's** until it tastes too salty and too spicy. Add 1 Tbsp. **vegetable Better Than Bouillon** until it has some roundness, not just heat and salt.

4. Add **potatoes** and **carrots**. Water should cover them by about 2 inches; add hot water as needed. After the water returns to a boil, cook *8–10 minutes*, until a knife pierces the outer flesh but the center is still firm. They finish with the rest of the pot.

5. Add **corn**. Cook *4 minutes*. Potatoes should still hold their shape.

6. Add **bell pepper**. Cook *2 minutes*.
7. Add **crab**, lid on. Cook *4 minutes*.
8. Add **zucchini**. Cook *2–3 minutes*, until the **crab** body is hot when you crack a knuckle, the **potatoes** are tender with a little resistance, the **corn** is hot through, and the **zucchini** is just tender and still slightly firm. Continue in *2 minute* stretches until the crab is hot. Do not soak.
9. Lift crabs and vegetables onto a platter. Dust with **Slap Ya Mama**.
10. Ladle 2 cups of the boil broth into a small saucepan. Reduce by about a quarter, *3–5 minutes*. Lower the heat. Whisk in 8 Tbsp. **butter**, then 1/4 cup **heavy cream**. Taste. Add **Slap Ya Mama** or **lemon** until it is spicy, salty, and thick enough to coat rice.
11. Fluff the rice, remove the **bay leaf**, and fold in 1/2 Tbsp. **butter**.
12. Spoon rice into bowls. Add vegetables and both halves of one **crab**. Spoon the sauce over. Serve at once—the crab is at its best right now.

Yield

- Serves *3* (one **crab** each)
- Leftover vegetables are expected

Equipment Required

- 20–24 qt. stockpot or water-bath canner
- Rice maker
- Fine-mesh strainer
- Small saucepan
- Tongs, ladle, spider or colander
- Whisk
- Chef's knife and cutting board
- Measuring cups and spoons
- Large platter

Mise en Place

- Thaw **crabs** overnight
- Halve **onions**, **garlic heads**, and **lemons**
- Scrub **potatoes**; cut **carrots**, **corn**, **bell pepper**, and **zucchini**
- Split each **crab** in half through the body
- Rinse 1½ cups **rice**
- Have ¼ cup **Tony Chachere's**, 1 Tbsp. **vegetable Better Than Bouillon**, 1½ tsp. **chicken Better Than Bouillon**, 8½ Tbsp. **butter**, and ¼ cup **heavy cream** ready

Ingredient Tips

- These **crabs** are already cooked. Heat them through. A long soak makes the meat rubbery.
- No lemons: use ¼ cup cider vinegar in the pot instead.
- Fish, lobster, or clam **Better Than Bouillon** is even better in the pot than vegetable. Do not use chicken in the boil—that belongs in the rice.
- **Tony Chachere's** and **Slap Ya Mama** are both salty. Tony's goes in the water. Slap Ya Mama goes on the platter.
- **Dehydrated soup vegetables**: garlic, onion, jalapeño, and cilantro.
- Large potatoes: halve them so they cook with the small ones.

Preparation Tips

- Width matters more than height. A crab that barely fits a dinner plate needs about 12 inches of pot diameter. Split the crabs if you are using a squat canner.
- Taste the water before any food goes in. Vegetables dilute it.
- The rice maker will likely finish before the boil. Leave it on warm. Fold in **butter** at serving.
- **Potatoes** keep cooking after corn, pepper, crab, and zucchini go in. Pull them to the platter as soon as they are tender, even if that is before the **crab** comes out.
- **Zucchini** turns to mush if it sits in the pot. Thick coins, last *2–3 minutes* only.
- Do not put **cream** in the big pot. Only in the small saucepan of reduced broth.

Make Ahead & Storage

- Thaw **crabs** in the refrigerator *12–24 hours*. Cold-water backup: sealed bag, *1–2 hours*, water changed every *30 minutes*.
- Leftover vegetables keep *3–4 days* refrigerated. Reheat in a splash of leftover broth.
- Leftover **crab** keeps *1–2 days*. Steam *4–5 minutes* to warm. Do not reheat twice.
- Sauce keeps *2 days*. Warm on low; do not boil.
- **Rice** keeps *3–4 days*. Reheat with a splash of water.

Serving Suggestions

- One whole **crab** (both halves) per bowl. Extra vegetables in the center of the table.
- Extra **Slap Ya Mama** and lemon wedges on the table.
- Next-day leftover vegetables and rice with the leftover sauce is lunch. The crab is a same-night dish.